FACTSHEET 7 • INTERPRETATION OF RESULTS

Say what it means, not what it is

Describing a number is not interpreting it. Your reader can read the table themselves.

The difference, in one example

	What it sounds like
Describing (not enough)	"Treatment success was 78.8%, and 8.9% of patients were lost to follow-up."
Interpreting (what we want)	"Almost four in five patients with an evaluated outcome completed treatment successfully, close to the national target of 80%. However, nearly one in ten was lost to follow-up, and a further 12 patients were transferred out and never traced. Together these 28 patients — more than one in six of the cohort — represent the gap between the reported success rate and the true one, and are where any effort to improve outcomes should be directed."

The four questions that turn a number into a finding

1. **So what?** Why should a busy programme manager care about this number? If you cannot answer, it may not belong in your results at all.
2. **Compared to what?** A number alone means nothing. Compare to the national target, to last year, to another district, to the published literature, or to another group in your own study.
3. **Is it real, or could it be chance / bias / error?** Consider the size of your denominator, how you selected patients, and how much data were missing before you believe your own result.
4. **What should change on Monday morning?** Operational research earns its name here. Name the action, and name who would take it.

Phrases to use, and phrases to retire

Instead of writing…	Write…
"The results were significant."	"Treatment success was 9 percentage points lower in women than men (73.5% vs 82.6%, p = 0.23) — a gap large enough to matter operationally, although our sample was too small to rule out chance."
"There was a correlation between distance and loss to follow-up."	"Patients lost to follow-up lived a mean of 16.5 km from their facility compared with 9.9 km among those completing treatment — but the *medians* were almost identical (7.6 km vs 6.9 km). The gap reflects a few very remote patients, not a general pattern."
"More research is needed."	"Whether decentralised drug pick-up would reduce these losses should be tested before it is scaled up nationally."
"The data showed…"	"We found…" (Data do not show things. You found them.)
"It is well known that…"	"X et al. reported… In our setting we found…"

Three interpretation traps

Trap 1 — Confusing statistical and operational importance

A difference can be statistically significant and operationally trivial (a 0.3 kg weight difference), or non-significant and operationally vital (a 9-point gap in treatment success in a small district). **Always interpret the size of the difference, not only the p-value.**

Trap 2 — Claiming cause from association

Patients who live further away are lost more often. That does *not* prove distance causes loss — remote patients may also be poorer, or have less contact with health workers. Use **'was associated with'**, and keep 'caused' for experiments.

Trap 3 — Interpreting what you did not measure

If 29% of your patients have unknown HIV status, you cannot make a confident statement about HIV and outcomes. **The missing data are themselves your finding** — and often the more actionable one.

The interpretation sentence — a template you can fill in

Fill this in for each of your main results

"Among **[who, N]** in **[where, when]**, we found **[the finding, with numbers]**. This is **[higher / lower / similar]** than **[the comparison]**. A likely explanation is **[reason]**, although **[limitation]**. This suggests that **[who]** should **[do what]**."

Liafuan importante • Key words in Tetum

Result	**Rezultadu**
Meaning	**Signifikadu**
Explain	**Esplika**
Compare with	**Kompara ho**
Because of	**Tanba**
Recommendation	**Rekomendasaun**
Conclusion	**Konkluzaun**